

A cystogram is a short X-ray test of your bladder. The bladder is gently filled with dye through a catheter so it shows up clearly on X-ray. This helps your surgeon check that a repair has healed and does not leak. It can also look for a leak, an abnormal connection, or urine flowing back toward the kidneys.

About This Test

The bladder is hard to see on a plain X-ray. A cystogram fills it with **contrast dye** that shows up white. This shows the shape of the bladder and whether it holds fluid. Your surgeon may order a cystogram to:

- Check that a **surgical repair has healed** and does not leak, often before a catheter is removed
- Look for a **leak** after an injury or surgery
- Find an abnormal connection (a **fistula**) between the bladder and another organ
- Check for urine flowing back toward the kidneys (**reflux**)

How the dye goes in depends on you:

- If you have **no tube**, a small catheter is placed just for the test.
- If you have a **urethral catheter** or a **suprapubic tube**, the dye usually goes through it. No new tube is needed.

Is It Safe?

Yes. A cystogram is a common, low-risk test. It uses a small amount of X-ray, and the water-based dye leaves your body in your urine. Most people feel only fullness or mild pressure. A urine infection, brief burning or cramping can happen, but these are uncommon and usually mild.

Learn the Terms

Cystogram

An X-ray of the bladder taken while it is filled with dye.

Bladder

The muscle sac that stores urine until you urinate.

Contrast dye

A liquid that shows up white on X-ray so the bladder can be seen.

Catheter

A thin, soft tube used to fill the bladder with dye.

Suprapubic tube

A catheter that drains the bladder through the lower belly. The dye can go through it.

Fistula

An abnormal connection between the bladder and another organ.

Reflux

Urine flowing back from the bladder toward the kidneys.

Voiding images

Extra X-ray pictures taken while you urinate, when needed.

Will it hurt? Most people feel only fullness or mild pressure as the bladder fills, not sharp pain. If a catheter is placed for the test, you may feel brief stinging. Tell the team if you are uncomfortable; they can slow down or stop. The test usually takes about 15–30 minutes.

How to Get Ready

There is very little to do. In most cases:

- You can **eat and drink normally** and take your **usual medicines**, unless told otherwise.
- If you have a catheter or suprapubic tube, **leave it in**. The dye often goes through it.
- You can usually **drive yourself home**.

Tell your team ahead of time if you:

- Have had a reaction to X-ray dye
- Take a blood thinner
- Could be pregnant. X-rays are usually avoided in early pregnancy.
- Have signs of a urine infection, such as burning or fever. The test may be moved to another day.

What Happens During the Test

- 1 You lie on an X-ray table. A small catheter is placed, or your tube is connected.
- 2 The dye slowly runs into the bladder while X-ray pictures are taken. Hold still and breathe normally.
- 3 You may be asked to **urinate** so the team can see the bladder empty.
- 4 A catheter placed for the test is removed. A tube you already had stays in.

After the Test

- You can usually go back to **normal activities right away**.
- **Mild burning or pink urine** for a day or so is common. Drink extra water.

Call the office that did your test if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Pain or belly cramping that gets worse instead of better
- A catheter or tube that stops draining

Go to an emergency department if:

- You cannot urinate and your bladder feels full or painful
- Heavy bleeding, or urine like red wine or with clots
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

1. A cystogram is a quick X-ray that checks the bladder for a leak.
2. Leave any catheter or tube in place. It is often used for the test.
3. Mild burning or pink urine for a day is normal. Drink extra water.